

Melanerpes formicivorus

Acorn woodpecker



Length 9 in (23 cm)
Weight 2½–3¼ oz (65–90 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location W. North America to N. South America



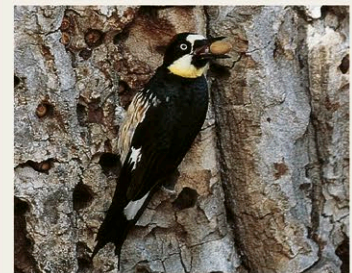
Dry acorns may comprise half of the daily food intake of the acorn woodpecker, which has a unique habit of storing acorns (see panel, right). It is also known to feed on other seeds, sap, and fruit. Insects form important food for the nestlings. Both sexes have

red crowns, but the forecrown is black in females. The tail and bill are moderately long. Restricted to oak and pine-oak woodland, this sociable woodpecker is often found in a group or breeding unit of 3–12 individuals, who share work on the communal acorn store and on building the nest, and defend the common territory that contains foraging sites, sap trees, the group larder, roosts, and the nest site. The acorn woodpecker is characterized by a complex breeding pattern that may be described as “polygynandrous”. Pairs may breed alone, but are typically assisted by males and females that usually belong to previous broods. Helping males participate in reproduction only after their mother has been displaced by another female.

**CONTRASTING COLORS**

The acorn woodpecker has bold, shiny, black, white, and red plumage that makes it easily recognizable.

STORING ACORNS



The acorn woodpecker drills small, neat holes in tree bark, and jams an acorn firmly into each one. Working together, birds belonging to a single breeding unit can store up to 50,000 acorns in one “granary tree,” creating a store of food to last them through the winter.

Sphyrapicus varius

Yellow-bellied sapsucker



Length 8¾ in (22 cm)
Weight 2½–2¾ oz (60–80 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North and Central America, Caribbean Islands



The yellow-bellied sapsucker drills holes into trees to extract sugary sap. A series of holes are chiseled into the trunks of broadleaved trees such as maple, fruit trees, birch, and poplar. After a short while, the bird returns to feed on the sap oozing out, and on the insects attracted by the sap. This bird has a mewing call-note and drums slowly and irregularly.

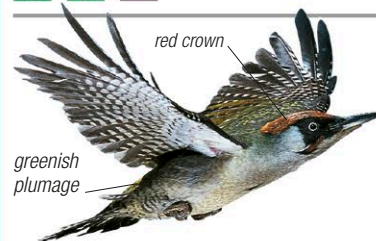
*Picus viridis*

European green woodpecker



Length 12½ in (32 cm)
Weight 7 oz (200 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, W. to C. Asia, N. Africa



Like the northern flicker (see below), the European green woodpecker feeds mainly on the ground, although it uses trees as a refuge, and as places to breed. It has an exceptionally long tongue—even by woodpecker standards—and it uses it to probe into ant nests, extracting them with its sticky tip. The green woodpecker has a loud, laughlike call and steeply undulating flight.

Dendrocopos major

Great spotted woodpecker



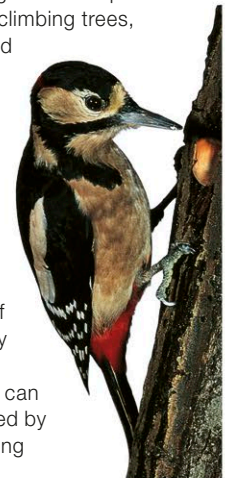
Length 8–9½ in (20–24 cm)
Weight 2½–3½ oz (65–100 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe, Asia, N. Africa



This small, black and white woodpecker has a red lower belly and undertail coverts. The male has a red band across the nape. As is typical in

woodpeckers, the strong feet, stiff tail, bill, and tongue of this species are adapted for climbing trees, drilling holes, and probing into cavities. The great spotted woodpecker feeds on fruit, berries, sap from trees, insects and their larvae, and even nestlings of other birds. Early in the breeding season, the bird can be easily detected by the loud drumming sound it makes.

*Dryocopus martius*

Black woodpecker



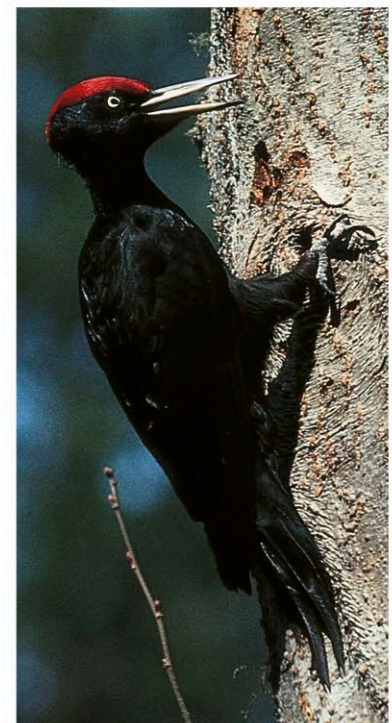
Length 18 in (45 cm)
Weight 13 oz (350 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern

Location Europe to Asia



This crow-sized bird is Eurasia's largest woodpecker, easily recognized both by its size and by its jet-black plumage and crimson crown. Females have a smaller crown patch than males, placed farther back, but apart from this the 2 sexes are the same. The black woodpecker lives in mature forests and woodland, where it actively chisels out prey that is hidden deep within living and dead wood. It feeds mainly on tunneling insects, such as sawfly grubs and ants, and, when probing for food, it can hack out vertical gashes up to 20 in (50 cm) long. This woodpecker's excavations produce woodchip the size of clothes' pins, which build up in piles on the forest floor. It also pecks at cones, often wedging them in the stumps of fallen

trees. This bird lays up to 6 eggs, in holes that it carves out every year. Old holes are very useful to other birds, which take them over when their original owner moves on.

*Colaptes auratus*

Northern flicker



Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Weight 3½–6 oz (100–175 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North and Central America



The northern flicker has a long, pointed, and slightly curved bill. During confrontations, the bill points forward, and the head and body engage in swinging movements,

while the tail and wings are flicked and spread. Often found on the ground, this bird feeds mainly on ants, digging into the earth and pillaging ant nests, with the help of its long tongue. When feeding arboreally, it usually concentrates on the dead parts of a tree. The female, shown here, lacks the black mustachial stripe of the male.

